

Lin-ex?

Dear Sir,

I want to share an experience that a friend of mine had recently. We are currently studying in the second year of our MCA course. He bought a Compaq Presario system and since we have Unix as a practical subject we decided to install Linux on the machine so we could get a feel of the operating system. After having partitioned his drive, he happened to contact his dealer for the sound and video card driver CD for Windows. At this point, the dealer informed us that we should not load any OS other than Windows, which was provided on the system. He also claimed that the company would 'suspend' the warranty on the PC for one year if we insisted on using anything other than Windows. He insists that my friend does not have the right to install another OS. What do we do about this situation?



VENKATESH
Via e-mail

digit

Dear Venkatesh,

Anyone who has bought a branded computer should be able to expect assistance from the manufacturer/vendor at all times. While it is understandable that the terms of warranty do have some exceptions, mostly related to hardware, it would be absurd to say that installing Linux would disqualify you from availing of the warranty on the hardware that you have purchased.

In addition to this, after buying a branded PC, you should be able to expect support and drivers for Linux, especially since it has been around for 10 years now and is reasonably popular.

Compaq has clarified to us, however, that while they do not provide support for problems related to the usage of Linux on their Presario products, the warranty on the hardware will still be valid even if someone decides to install Linux (or another non-Windows OS) on it.

A taxing situation

Dear Karan,

In a recent comparison test of anti-virus software that was conducted by your Test Centre, I found the price of Norton Antivirus 2001 listed as Rs 1,600. I decided that I needed to buy the software and subsequently called the vendor listed in the magazine. However the vendor quoted a price of Rs 2,500 which he claimed included Octroi and other taxes. Please provide the readers with the final price inclusive of all taxes or at least mention what taxes are extra because without this the prices are extremely misleading.

ROHINTON
Via e-mail



digit

Dear Rohinton,

This has clearly been an oversight on our part. While providing the prices inclusive of all taxes for all products is not possible for us to do—because these vary from place to place—we shall make it a point to specify wherever extra taxes are applicable.

Talking through an old hat

Hi,

This is in response to the feedback that you had in Dialog in August, on the article 'The Promised Goal' which was carried in an earlier issue of Digit. While I agree with the students when they say that their Labs are using outdated hardware and software and that their curriculum is outdated, I am worried by the attitude of engineering students who think that they only need to know what is hot on the market. I think people need to concentrate more on the fundamentals of development, which would help them upgrade themselves for modern platforms. My advice would be for engineers to get rid of this 'labourer' mentality and use their heads instead of just their hands.

ANUPAM AROHI
Via e-mail



Dear Karan,

That was a nice article by Manu Khanna ('The Promised Goal', July 2001). While I agree with your views on the state of computer education in our graduation colleges, I think that this is just the tip of the iceberg.

After my B.Sc. I joined an MCA course hoping to get a nice degree in computers and expecting excellent course materials. What I got instead was Pascal and C in the first semester, COBOL in the second and C++ in the third. What else do you ask? Well, 8085/86 architecture, data structures and graphics (only algorithms), and the others including Economics, Accountancy, etc. Is this the best course structure that an MCA student can expect? Eventually, after spending lakhs of rupees, we stand nowhere.

You have conveniently stated that "...the system at the PG level is more comprehensive and up-to-date...". You mention somewhere that AICTE and NBA conduct evaluations of the course structures and what not. You could conveniently praise them so, because you've only seen the brighter side like the Punjab University, Mumbai University, etc in the metros or big towns. But in the smaller universities the situation is similar to what you have described in the general graduation colleges and engineering colleges. Am I wrong in feeling cheated?

MITHUN KUMAR
Via email

digit

Dear Anupam,

You are absolutely right when you say that only someone with strong fundamentals can be successful in the long run. However, I think that you will agree that they can only take you so far. While strong fundamentals can provide an excellent platform for you to move ahead there are other skills that you do need to develop. Even someone with great fundamentals will find himself at a disadvantage if he is not able to adapt himself and increase his knowledge, say learn more about new programming languages and platforms. The point is that after spending a decent amount of money and more importantly three years of your time you expect that you have more than just the fundamentals. Even if the course does not provide all the knowledge that is necessary to help students to be successful, it is necessary that the institutions consider it their goal to do so. From what we have seen and heard it is clear that very few are striving to do this.